and to dress, drill and manoeuvre in the European manner. At the same time de Lannoy’s Dutch officers employed their engineering skills in building forts and defences, in particular a line of fortifications in the north that became known as the Nedunkotta or ‘Travancore Line’.



The ruins of Eustachius de Lannoy’s church below the walls of Uthayagiri Fort, near Nagercoil.

Scarcely acknowledged today, this ‘Europeanisation’ of Travancore’s army and its defences was the decisive factor that enabled Travancore to take on and annex its neighbours to north and south and so secure for itself the pepper trade. With the defeat of the forces of the Zamorin of Calicut at Purakkad in 1756, Marthanda Varma became